

## **STAGE 3 ENGLISH HOLIDAY WORK????**

Read the following:

- Boys to men
- Chapter Two Manhood – Seven Steps to Manhood
- Chapter Twelve – Men's groups

You need to answer the following on each reading, this does not have to be in prose writing, but you need to make detailed notes on each one.

1. Make detailed annotations on each reading
2. Explain how each reading demonstrates your understanding of the ideas/issues presented.
3. Explain what does it mean to be male in the socio-cultural context depicted

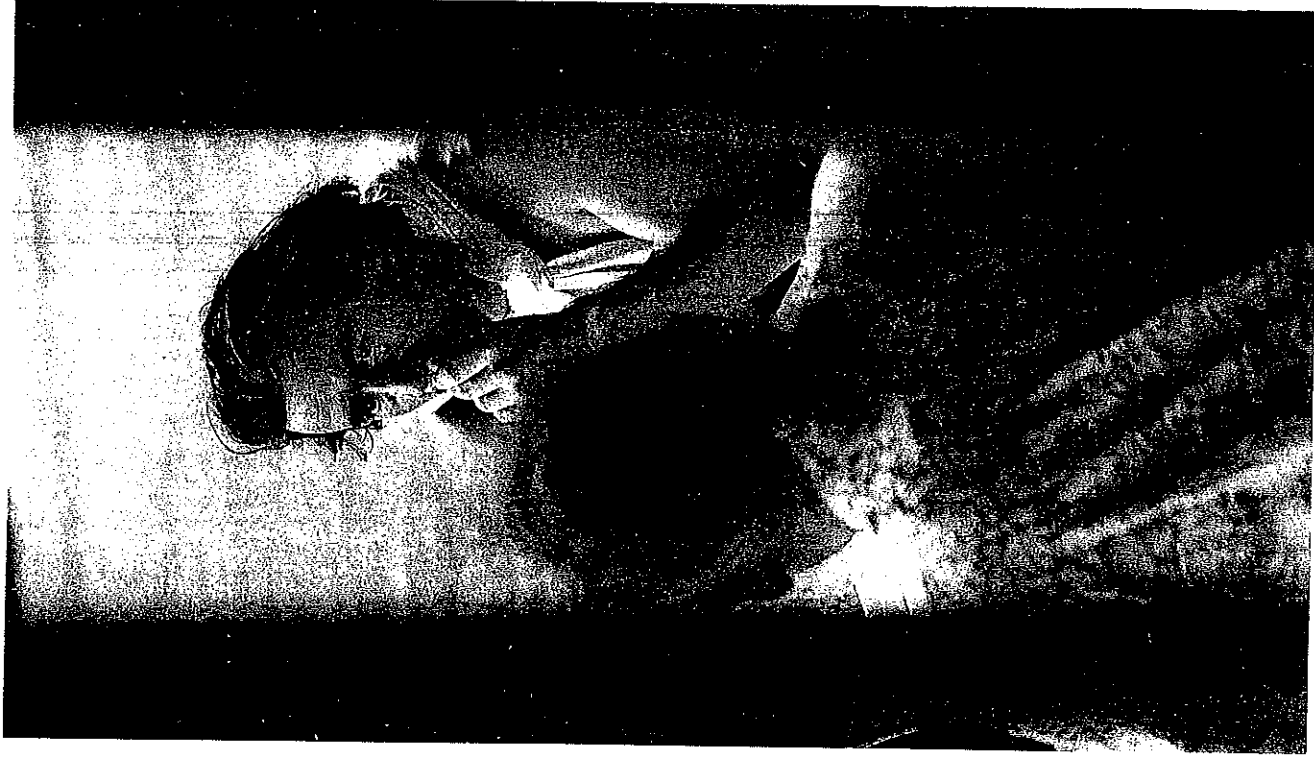
Write an essay, one hour only:

Using a text studied highlight your understanding of how society depicts the view of males and masculinity in general.

# 12 Men's Groups

**H**opefully, reading this book has given you some good ideas for your own life, which you may have already begun to implement. But perhaps you are feeling a little overwhelmed. One problem with the whole 'self-help' and 'self-improvement' scene is the expectation that we can change things all on our own. Twentieth century man has been plagued by this illusion. When this solitary approach fails, we conclude that nothing can be changed after all, and give up. So today, most young men are brashly over confident, and most older men are depressed!

Since writing the first edition of *Manhood*, I have learned some things about the importance of having a male community. To make personal change easier, and to make global change possible, we have to build and belong to a community of men who are working towards similar goals. Even small groups of men who are willing to meet regularly and talk, can give each other enormous insights, enormous amounts of encouragement, and occasional kicks in the bum - all essential to keeping you open and moving towards liberation! If you want your life as a man to really get



moving, then you could probably get a lot out of a men's group. Here are some guidelines if you are interested.

## The growth of men's groups

In a lounge room not far from where you are reading this, its odds on that a group of eight or nine men are meeting every couple of weeks to talk about their lives. Their wives or partners are happy to vacate the house on that night, because they like the results – a happier, more balanced, stronger and more peaceful man.

We know of several hundred men's groups in Australia; there are doubtless many more quietly getting on with it. Overseas the picture is the same. Therapist-turned-activist Guy Corneau has singlehandedly founded 300 groups in Canada; there are thousands in the US. In the UK, Germany, South America and New Zealand, men's groups are forming, writing newsletters, 'internetting', holding conferences and getting excited. Different emphases are emerging: in the US there are special efforts being made by ghetto groups, and men of different races. In Australia good links are being forged with Aboriginal people, and major focuses are the mentoring of adolescent boys and helping fathers do their jobs.

As with every new movement the media is only just starting to comprehend its significance and is now moving on from simplistic stereotyping. (The Women's Movement and Conservation Movements came in for the same treatment.) The Men's Movement has been lampooned for its inwardness, even for its emotionality. One TV network regularly reused a piece of video footage to represent men's gatherings. It showed a man in deep grief, supported by some other men. He had just acknowledged the sexual abuse he suffered as a child and the hurt he still carried. Yet it was presented as if it was some Californian executive indulging himself for the sake of it. It's typical of the way we set men up – go to war, survive divorce, be a policeman,

pull children's bodies out of mangled cars, but don't tell us about your grief.

## How men's groups work

Men's groups can be emotional at times. Something very freeing happens when a private space is set aside, when the rules are 'no bullshitting', and 'say what you feel'. 'If men know their stories will be heard and honoured, then a great deal finds its way to the surface.'

Men's groups are also very practical. The chosen topic of the night may be 'how to discipline your kids', or 'how to break out of an alienating career and make time to live'. It might be some frank discussion about sex, or it might be more crisis-driven – shoring up a man wounded from marital combat, or a man whose wife has just that week been diagnosed with cancer. I've listened in men's groups to older men talk about war trauma, honestly, for the first time after decades of silent suffering.

Young men find surrogate fathers and uncles in the group, to replace the absent drones their real fathers appeared to be. The ethics of men's groups are strong – particularly about never acting (or even speaking) violently to women, children or each other. Men's-group talk has a style that is very different to women's talk – there's less tiptoeing, and less tendency to agree with everything you say.

Men's groups usually meet in homes, occasionally they are church-based or in a health centre. Most are general purpose, some are specifically for men with violence problems or health or marital concerns. A group may close its membership once it is running, though some will invite new members periodically. The commonest way to start is to invite a few friends and begin your own. Some groups use a book (such as this one) as a discussion starter or generate a list of topics agreed by members. Leadership tends to be rotated, rather than having no leader at all – acknowledging that men like structure and are goal oriented. Men's groups

usually have rules (no put-downs, confidentiality) and there is a tendency to confront bullshit or irresponsibility. 'You're neglecting your bloody kids mate ! When are you going to wake up to yourself !' - 'Well, sure you could leave your wife, but you'd be an idiot to do it. Why don't you talk to her and tell her what you're feeling.' 'You're tired, mate. You and your wife need a holiday.' And so on. You don't have to 'spill your guts' in a men's group - there isn't any pressure. Perhaps for that very reason, though, you soon find yourself hoeing in - prompted by the similarities of your own experiences with those being shared by the other men. You get practical tips for living and feel you can breathe more deeply, all at the same time! It adds a sense of relaxation to your life - (quite different to getting drunk or going fishing) because the changes are cumulative. Your life starts to make more sense.

Most men's groups reach a point where they organise to get away for weekends. Also in groups where most men are fathers, activities are often planned to include the youngsters. Some groups, such as YMCA Explorers, exist specifically for dads and daughters, or dads and sons, to spend time together supported by some resources and structure.

## Where this may lead

What about the big picture? In time the Men's Movement will lead to legislative and workplace changes. Our economy and the wider world will be affected in many ways. (A national newsletter is advertised in the back of this book). People will consider other necessary changes: the way that boys are treated in schools; the access situation for fathers; exploitation of young men in sport, sexual abuse and exploitation of boys, men in the military; the situation in prisons; the right of children to have and know their fathers; and the prevention of rape and harassment of women. The field is wide.

In a sense, the Men's Movement is a vital missing piece in this jig-saw of human change. Who knows where it might take us ? If you're a man, you're part of it and your actions will make a difference. If you're a woman reading this, we ask for your support and welcome your input.

Warmest wishes

Steve Biddulph  
Coffs Harbour  
Spring, 1995.

### SAMPLE EXPOSITORY RESPONSE

Read, annotate and respond to the feature article, "What's Wrong With Boys", making connections with other texts read on the theme of masculinity.

The feature article, "What's wrong with boys" by Susan Maushart, states that "In schools across Australia, boys are falling further and further behind girls". The report suggests that this may be due to the absence of fathers, either completely or emotionally, from their life. Or the difference in how boys are "hardwired". Either way, boys are suffering from a crisis of masculinity. After reading, "What's wrong with boys", I feel that evidence that girls have been out performing boys is overwhelming: "Girls consistently dominate the HSC top achievers list", "Five out of the top ten high schools in the state last year were girls only schools", and in 2005, the "All-rounders list" gender split was 60/40 in the girls' favour. I believe the blame for the boys' underachievement cannot be attributed to any one thing, but more to a multitude of issues amongst boys and men and "the problem" in me is described in Manhood.

Manhood suggests that men in today's society "don't have a life"; that they 'fake'. They suppress their emotions and pretend to be something that they are not in order to conform to the stereotypical expectations of a man. As a result of this, boys are growing up without adequate role models, or as "Boys to Men" states, "emotionally absent fathers". I believe that without a role model, a young boy will model his ideas of what it is to be a man through other means such as through television, computer games, movies and the media. Rarely do any of these portray anything other than the stereotypical rugged, emotionless, fearless and uncaring man.

Many young boys are growing up trying to "act out" what they believe it is to be a real man. If their views of masculinity do not allow for the boy to show characteristics of a "whole" human being, such as being able to show emotion and being able to love, there will be a problem for the boy and a problem for society. This problem can be seen already. "What's wrong with boys" states that "a boy will act according to who he's with". Boys have a fear of being labelled "girl, geek or gay", and doing schoolwork or achieving has been labelled as "uncool". The young boy, upholding his own view of manhood will protect his reputation and not do anything that could be seen as weak, caring or feminine. The boys do not know what real masculinity is as their father could not teach what they themselves did not know.

As I read the feature article, a constant question intrigued me. Where did this stereotypical and previously universally accepted view of masculinity come from? Since before civilization, males have been the hunters, the gatherers. This is due to the fact they are naturally stronger. Females have been the nurturers as they were the ones who gave birth. Echoed throughout all articles based around masculinity is the fact that males and females are "hardwired" differently. This may have been essential to survival at one stage in evolution, but the usefulness of this hardwiring seems to be fading away in the context of today's social circumstances.

It is now easier for a woman to do a man's job. Gone are the days where males hunted food with their hands and spears as now a stroll to the local supermarket can put a meal on the table – hardly a task too demanding for a woman. As more and more women enter the workforce, and more and more men elect to stay at home, the gap of gender inequality closes and society edges towards equality between the sexes. Femininity is constantly remodelling itself, though only now is masculinity slowly starting to remould itself to fit into today's society.

Women had the women's rights movement that pushed for equality. The view of what it is to be a woman changed. Now a woman can vote, work or even join the army. Men have had no such movement. Instead many men were left "lonely" and "depressed" when their newly empowered wives left them. The social view of men towards masculinity is still primitive. A man must be cold, hard and emotionless. While in the past, men's emotions have been "caged" up, there was a clear line between men's business and women's business. As that line blurs, I find it absurd that what society views as normal male behaviour and thoughts has not changed. I feel that a man's movement on a mass scale is inevitable.

Growing up, my father has never been "emotionally absent" or seemed as if he was pretending to be somebody that he was not. I have always been close to my parents and they have always been supportive of me. My father has been there as a good role model and I feel that because of this, it has been harder for me to directly relate to the generations of the feature articles.

Boys in today's society are being under-fathered. The fact that they are falling further and further behind girls in education is proof of this. The typical view of masculinity does not lend itself to the development of a balanced society. The way that males view masculinity must change if men and future men of society are to live healthier and happier lives. I believe we must universally start to accept and welcome such things as a male showing emotion or expressing how he feels. In my opinion, in today's society, true masculinity is having the courage to free yourself from the stereotypical or classic view of masculinity and is doing so, enable yourself to be who you are. To live your life as you. Not a fake shell of a person constantly trying to prove yourself. If what we know of masculinity is "hardwired" into our heads at birth, then we must teach young boys what is truly is to be a man.

With thanks to Jono Stewart